he said to them, ‘You are wondering whether to stay or go. / My own end is before me. / What solution can I give you?’

~

For the rest of Akbar’s life and reign, from 1600 to 1605, the empire, like Nuram Khan and the jewellers, would hang in precarious balance, between an ageing, anguished and often very angry emperor and his stubborn son.

A painting from about this time shows Salim, goblet in hand, lounging in a tent, one arm resting on the back of an attendant who offers him a golden plate – containing a snack, perhaps, to go with his drink, or possibly the opium he used, increasingly, as a substitute for alcohol.[2] Musicians, a man holding a book, another a sword, a pageboy fanning the prince comprise the rest of his court. At first glance, there is something louche about the scene – the informality of Salim’s pose, the crowding of pleasures, the fact that his sword is swaddled in cloth, unprepared for conquest or battle. And yet, for all the ease and luxury that emanates from it, the painting also conveys a compelling intensity of purpose. Despite the clear signs of indulgence, there is nothing unkempt about Salim’s appearance – he is both well dressed and well formed, the dark patches at his armpits, showing through his sheer muslin shirt, may be oil-based perfume, but they also communicate brawn. For all that his arm lies loose and familiar on his attendant’s back, Salim’s eyes are sharp and focused, and his face is deadly serious.

It was with such serious intent that Salim had begun to eye his father’s throne. Between 1598 and 1599, the two years before he decamped to Allahabad, Salim had shown little enthusiasm for military campaigns. Instead, he had fired his first salvo at an enemy closer to home: Abul Fazl. The historian was ‘always making snide remarks’ about the prince, Salim would write in his autobiography.[3] Naturally, then, Salim was keen to rid the court of Abul Fazl’s influence; and he did, indeed, manage to create a rift between Akbar and one of his last remaining friends.

Abul Fazl writes an extensive and overwrought account of the affair without revealing any precise details – only that he was too busy to attend ‘upon the Prince-Royal’ so that the ‘anger of that hot-tempered one blazed forth’. Abul Fazl was so upset, he even offered a Fire Test to prove his innocence – ‘I and my accuser [to] enter the furnace’ – but even this did not